Why do young Americans support redistribution?

Survey evidence on a widening U.S. age gap

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November 9, 2026

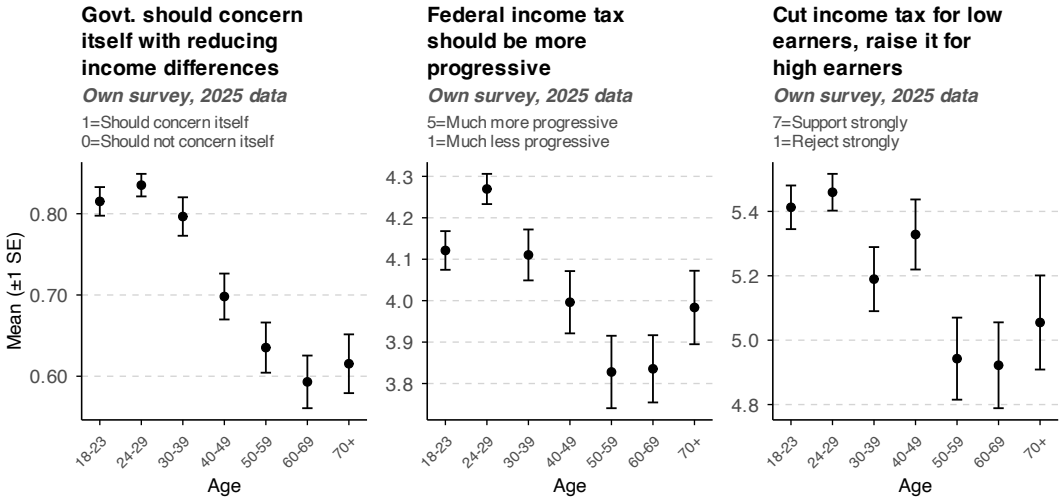
Do young Americans have different preferences?

If the election were held today, how would you vote on Proposition 40, the one-time tax on billionaires?

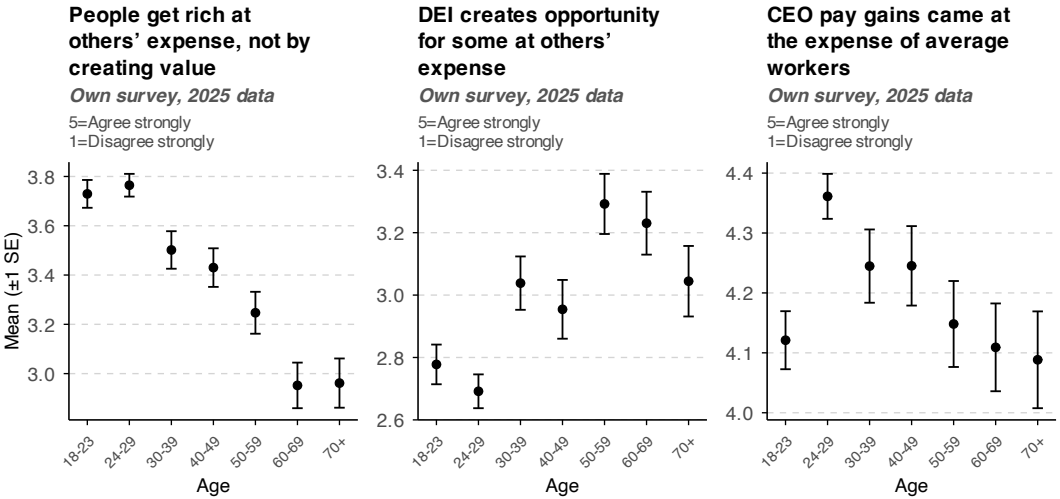
POLITICO / Citrin Center (UC Berkeley) / TrueDot poll of California likely voters, fielded October 9–14, 2026

	Age			
	18–29	30–44	45–64	65+
Yes	64%	62%	44%	28%
No	18%	25%	49%	63%
Undecided	18%	12%	6%	10%
N (unweighted)	68	226	314	301

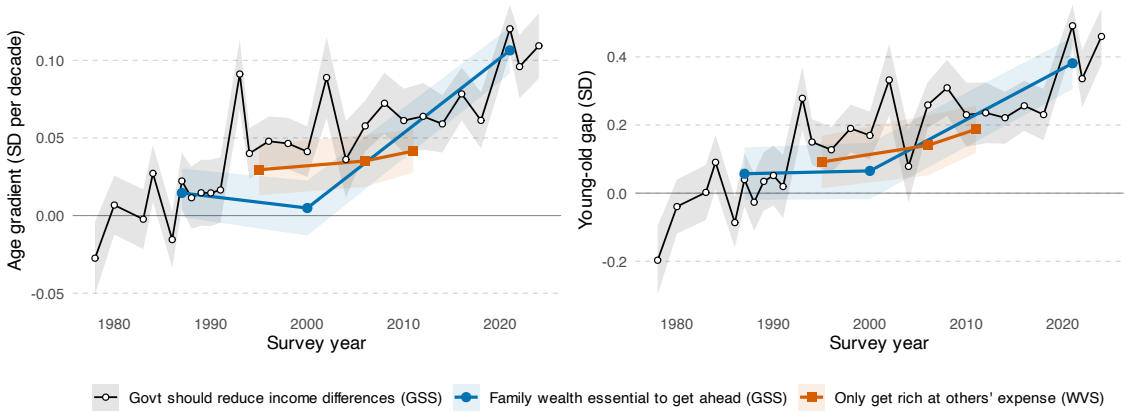
Current age gap on income redistribution



Current age gap on zero-sum beliefs



Redistribution and belief gaps over time



Life Cycle vs Beliefs?

Two competing hypotheses:

- Lifecycle: currently low income + time discounting, present financial stress, long-term career/lifestyle risk, prospect of upward mobility.

  Largely *self-interest*-driven.
- Belief divergence: experienced inequality, growth, mobility, housing prices, social safety net access, diversity, immigration. Shaped by political narratives and the supply of politicians/platforms.

  Largely *belief*-driven.

Summary of findings

1. It is not the economic position of the young: 26 measures of income, risk and prospects explain none of the gap.
2. It is what the young believe about the economy: zero-sum and deservingness beliefs account for much of the gap.
3. The age gap on redistribution grew from zero in the 1970s–80s to +0.5 SD today (half of the party gap, similar to the race gap, double the gender gap).
4. A similar age gap in beliefs has emerged.
   - Ongoing analysis: what drives these beliefs?

Our survey

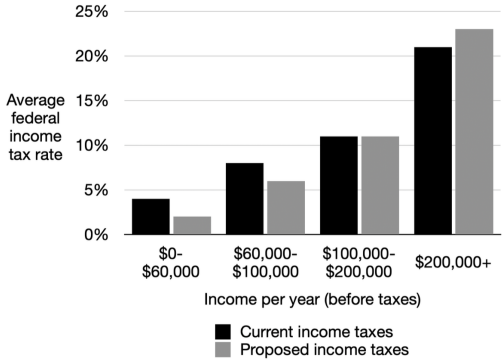
- Online survey of U.S. citizens, fielded on Prolific in spring 2025.
- $N = 2,415$, one half 18–30, one half > 30.
- 15 minutes on average, 92 questions.
- Covers current financial position, history, expectations, risks, beliefs about the economy, and values.

Questions asked

- Policy preferences: income redistribution (3), why preferences changed (2), alternative policies to support low-income (5).
- Economic position: current and expected income (12), future income needs (5), financial insecurity (4), AI/climate/housing/health risk (4), family/personal history (5), ambitions (5).
- Beliefs: incentive effects of taxation (2), zero-sum beliefs (4), mobility (4).
- Values: time discounting (7), generosity/universalism (2), materialism (2).

Core outcomes

1. Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?
2. Should the federal income tax be more progressive than it is now (redistributing more income from the rich to the poor)?
3. *Description of revenue-neutral tax.* Would you support or reject the proposed change?



Strongest correlates from forward selection

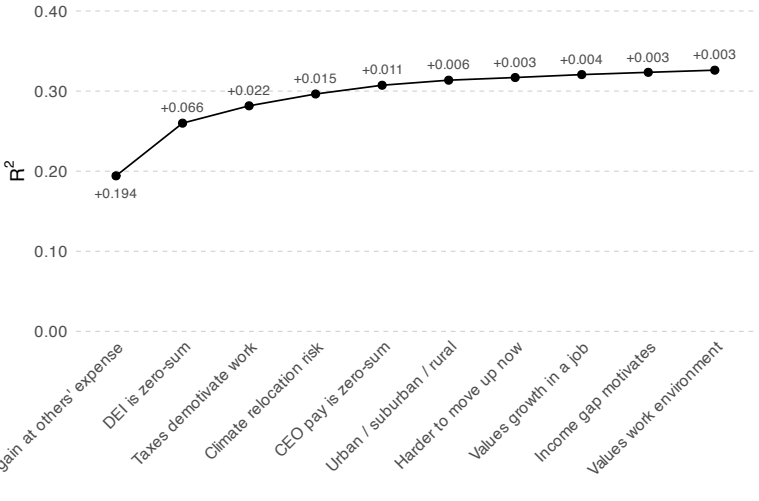
Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025. OLS, outcome and items in SD units; the ten items the add-one-in selects first.

Question	Alone	All ten
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	$+0.44^{***}$	$+0.22^{***}$
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	-0.38^{***}	-0.18^{***}
If taxes on high incomes are increased and taxes on low incomes are decreased, people will not work as hard.	-0.33^{***}	-0.12^{***}
What is the risk that you have to relocate due to climate events in the next 10 years?	$+0.23^{***}$	$+0.11^{***}$
Large gains in CEO and executive salaries have been at the expense of the salaries of average workers.	$+0.39^{***}$	$+0.12^{***}$
Would you consider your current location urban, suburban, or rural?	$+0.10^{***}$	$+0.08^{***}$
Is it harder or easier to move up in the U.S. now than when your parents were growing up?	-0.26^{***}	-0.06^{***}
Rank of "opportunities for growth and advancement" among five things valued in a job.	$+0.00$	-0.08^{***}
A large income gap is needed to motivate entrepreneurs to start businesses and innovate.	-0.30^{***}	-0.07^{***}
Rank of "a good work environment and colleagues" among five things valued in a job.	-0.05^{*}	-0.05^{**}
R^2		0.33

$N = 2{,}415$; standard errors 0.017–0.022; * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Strongest correlates: forward selection



Forward selection: starting from the four core beliefs (three zero-sum items and "income gaps motivate"), at each step we add the remaining candidate belief that most increases R^2, given everything already included. All variables z-scored on a common complete-case sample.

Strongest corrlates: Shapley decomposition

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025

Question	% of R^2
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	16.6%
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	13.9%
Large gains in CEO and executive salaries have been at the expense of the salaries of average workers.	12.1%
If taxes on high incomes are increased and taxes on low incomes are decreased, people will not work as hard.	9.1%
A large income gap is needed to motivate entrepreneurs to start businesses and innovate.	6.2%
— 83 questions with <5% omitted —	
Full model $R^2 = 0.37$, $N = 2{,}415$	

What accounts for the gap: Gelbach decomposition

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025

Question	Contribution	% of explained
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	-0.037	43.7%
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	-0.019	22.3%
Rank of "opportunities for growth and advancement" among five things valued in a job.	-0.014	16.3%
What is the risk that you have to relocate due to climate events in the next 10 years?	-0.010	12.2%
— 65 questions with <10% omitted —		
Age gradient: bivariate -0.211, with all covariates -0.126		40.4%
N = 2,255		

Discussion: is it zero-sum or deservingness?

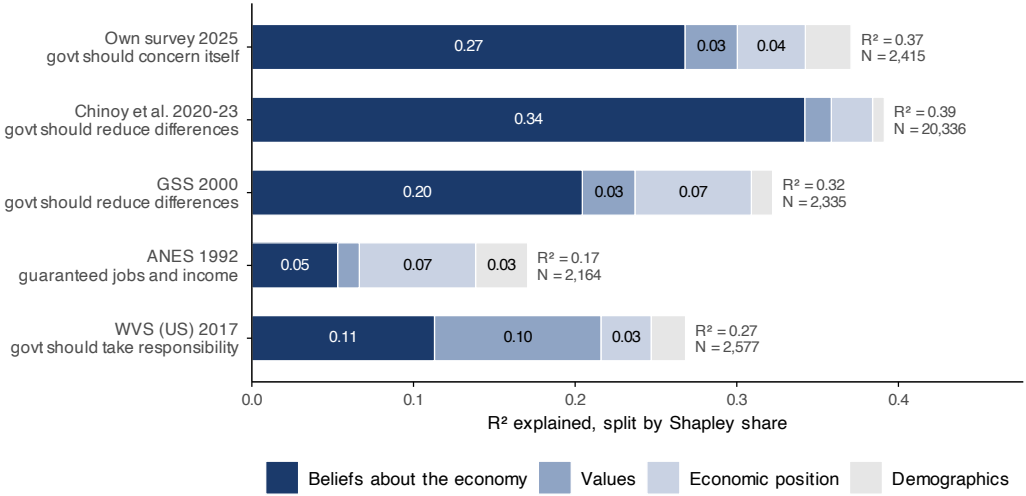
Related but distinct beliefs

- Positive-sum vs zero-sum: whether one's effort can grow the pie or one's gains are necessarily another's losses.
- Attribution/deservingness: whether one's gains were deserved or earned unfairly.

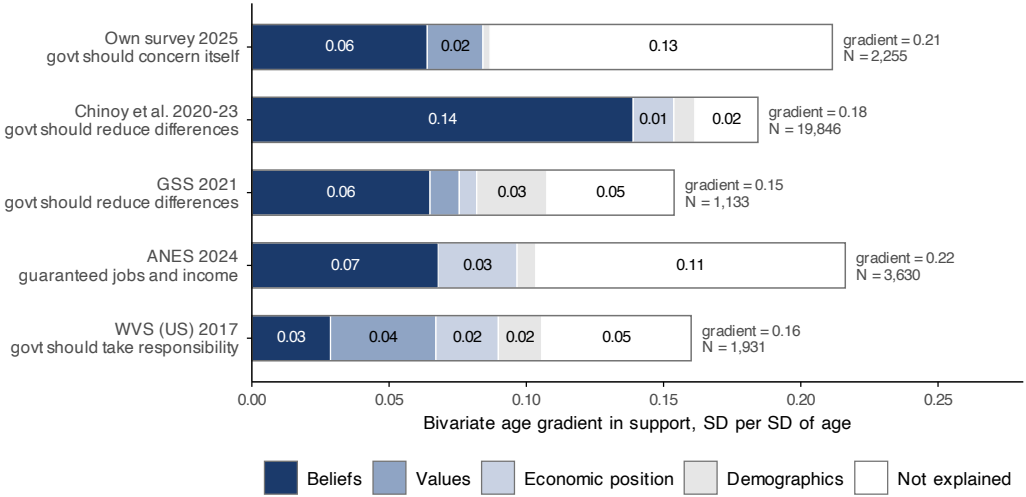
Observations

- Young people on average believe that CEOs are zero-sum but not DEI initiatives; zero-sum is not a universal belief.
- "Tax demotivates" and "gap motivates" address positive-sumness and predict preferences but have no age gap.

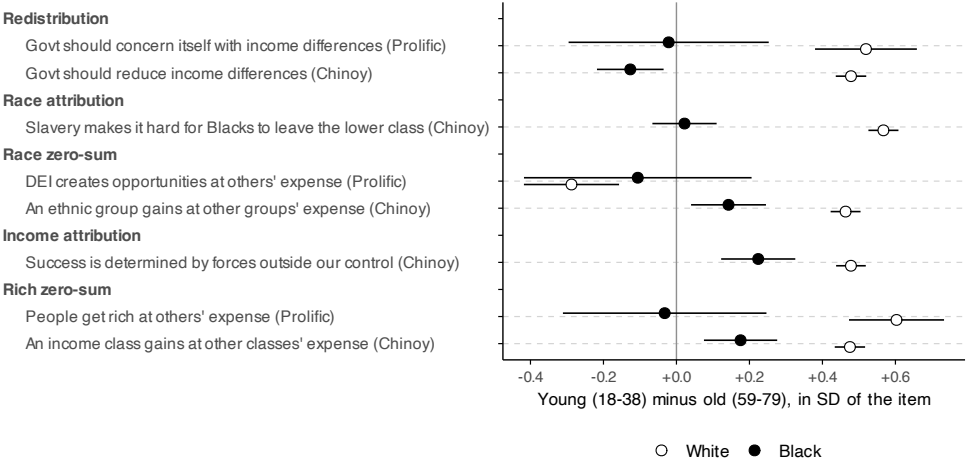
Comparing to other surveys: strongest correlates



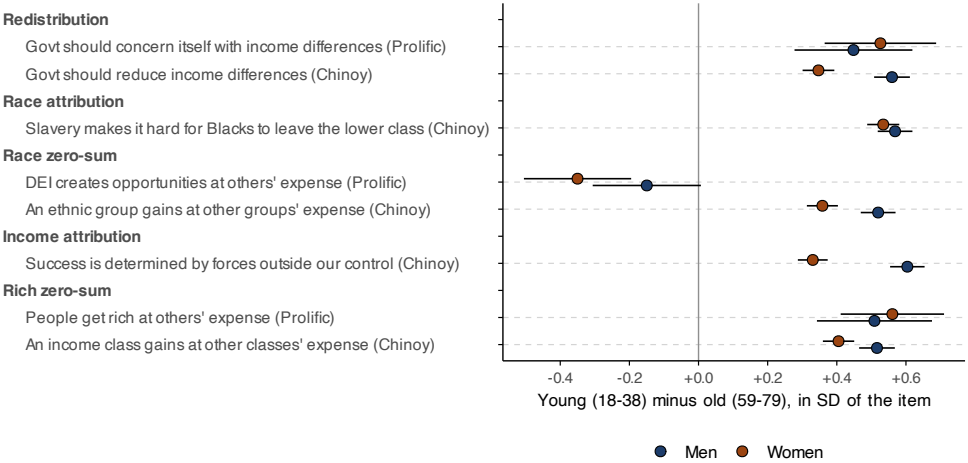
Comparing to other surveys: what accounts for the age gap



The age gradient by race

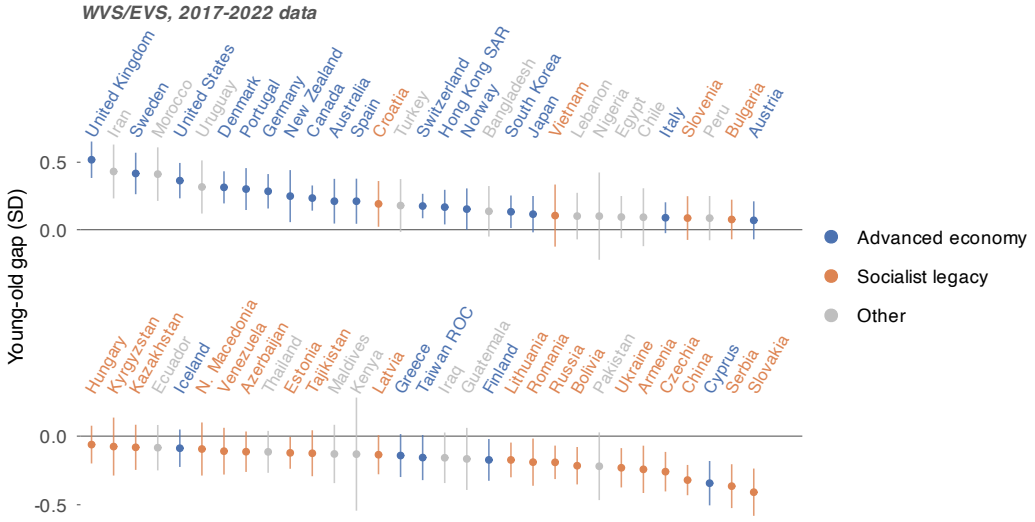


The age gradient: men and women

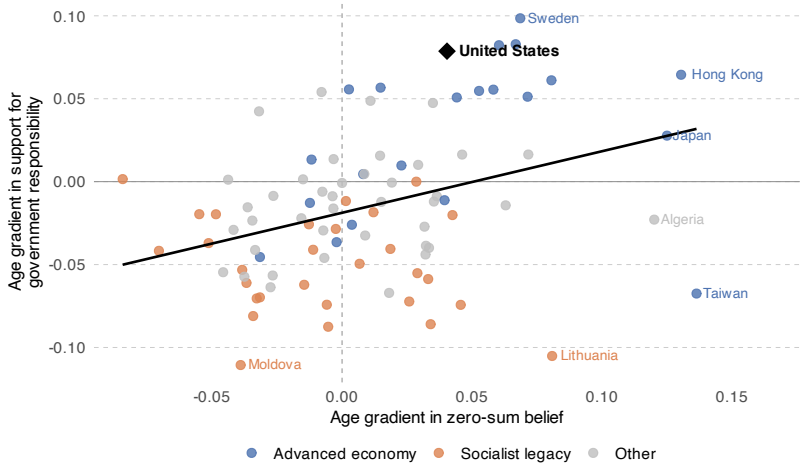


All races. Unweighted (neither survey ships weights); 95% intervals, HC1 standard errors.

Age gap across countries



Redistributive vs. zero-sum age gradient across countries



Slope 0.37, r = 0.36, 91 countries (WVS). Each axis: within-country slope on age, SD of the item per decade; positive = the young hold the view more.

Zero-sum beliefs and redistribution within countries

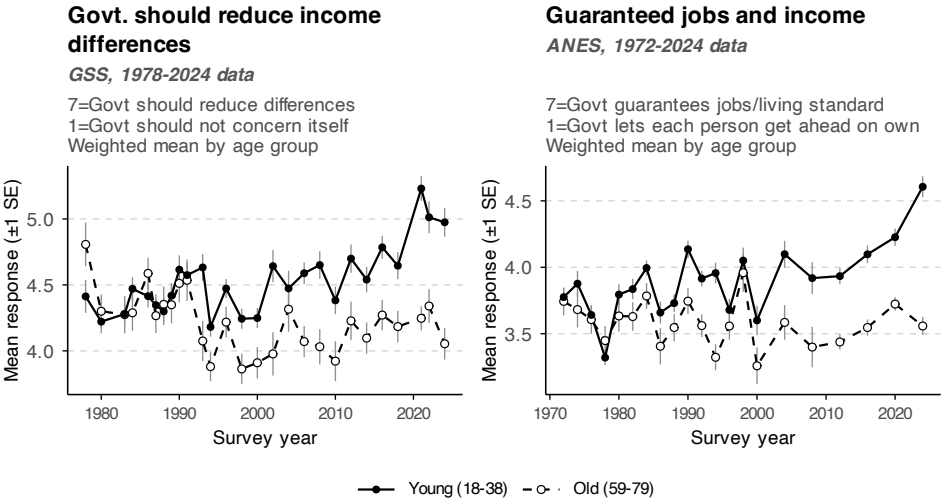
Individual-level WVS: redistribution on zero-sum belief

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
A. Incomes should be made more equal (E035)				
Zero-sum belief (E041)	0.117***	0.118***	0.107***	0.108***
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Within R^2	0.014	0.015	0.012	0.013
Observations	236,885	236,885	236,885	236,885
B. Government should take more responsibility (E037)				
Zero-sum belief (E041)	0.075***	0.075***	0.068***	0.069***
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.009)
Within R^2	0.006	0.006	0.005	0.005
Observations	238,268	238,268	238,268	238,268
Country FE	Yes	Yes		
Country × wave FE			Yes	Yes
Age control		Yes		Yes
Countries	92	92	92	92

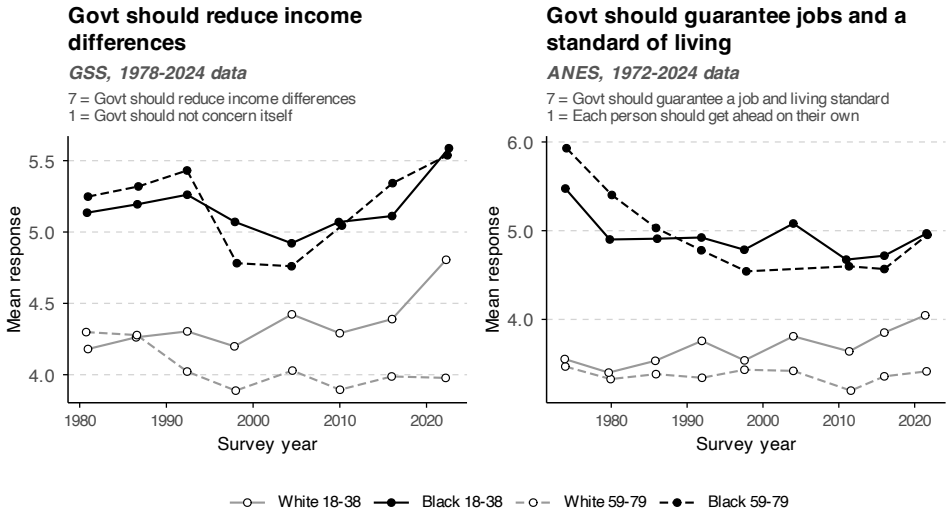
WVS waves carrying E041 (1990–2014), ages 18–79, weighted, SEs clustered by country. Items z-scored over the estimation sample (SD of the outcome per 1 SD of zero-sum); age control is age in decades. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Items on a 1–10 scale.

- E035: 1 = "Incomes should be made more equal" ... 10 = "We need larger income differences as incentives" (coded + = pro-equality).
- E037: 1 = "People should take more responsibility" ... 10 = "The government should take more responsibility" (coded + = pro-government).
- E041: 1 = "People can only get rich at the expense of others" ... 10 = "Wealth can grow so there's enough for everyone" (coded + = zero-sum).

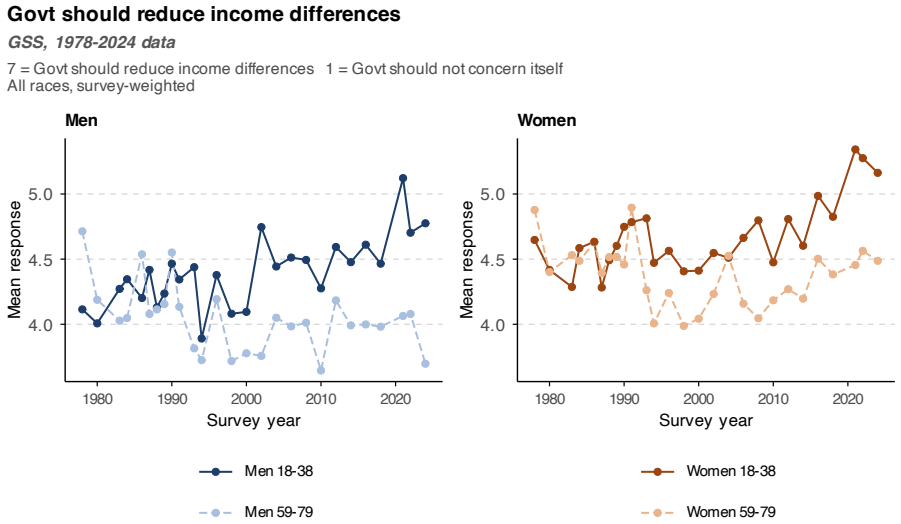
Young and old over time



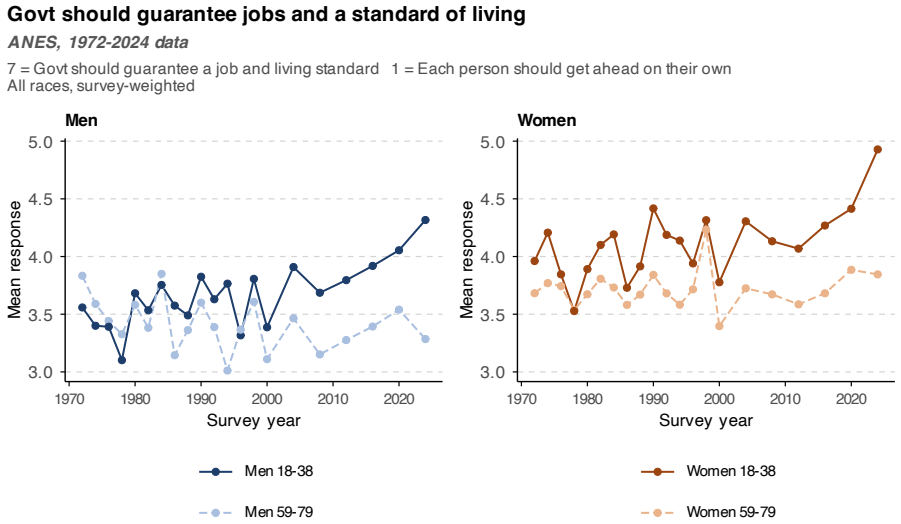
Young and old over time: white vs. Black



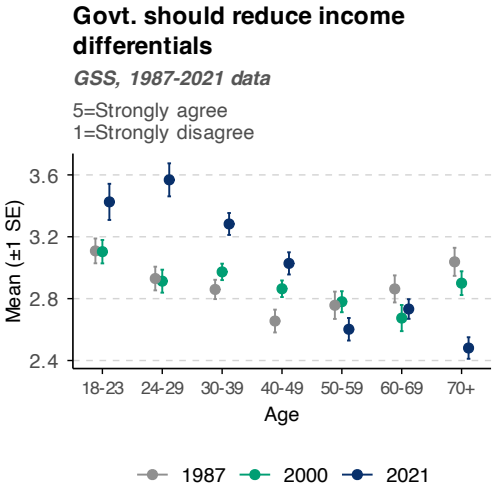
Young and old over time: men and women (GSS)

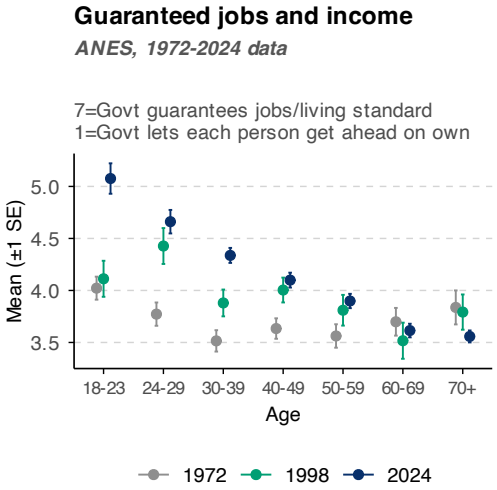


Young and old over time: men and women (ANES)

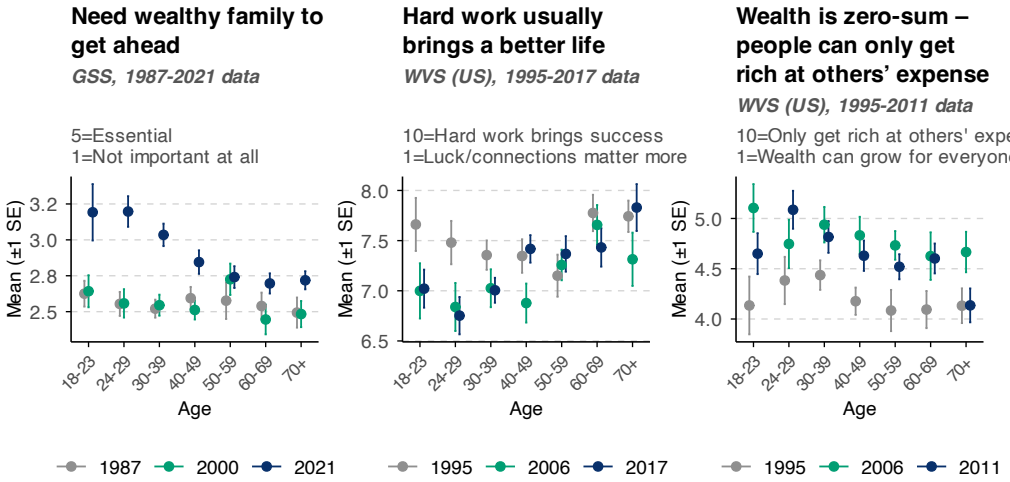


Cross-sectional age gradient steepening over time

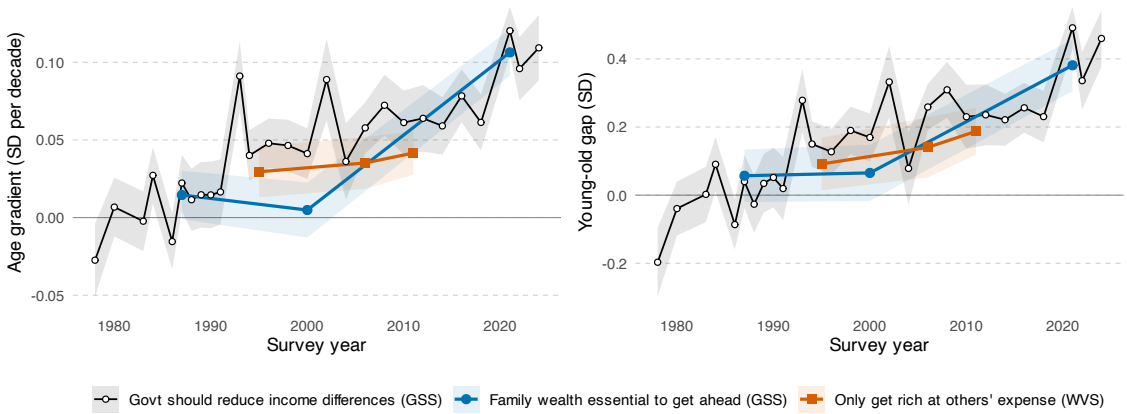




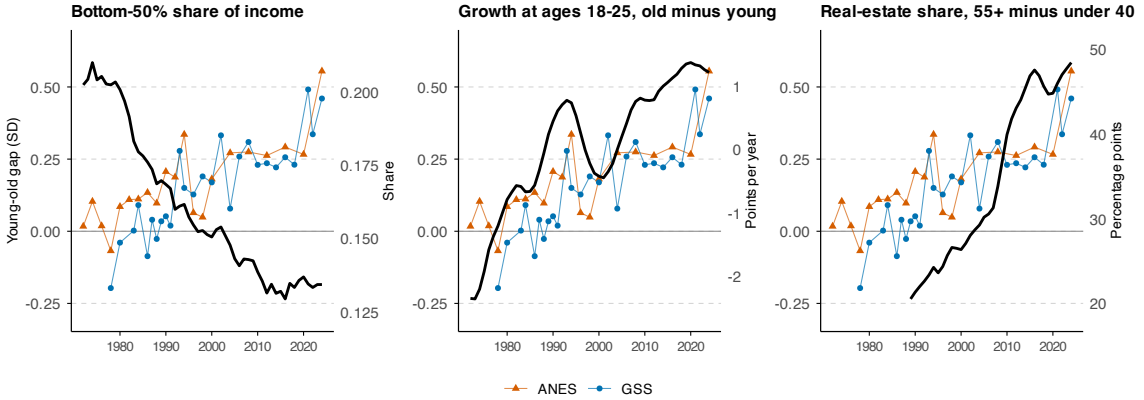
Steepening age gradient in zero-sum and deservingness beliefs



Redistribution and belief gaps over time



Inequality, growth, housing and the age gap



Real estate: share of US household real estate held by households aged 55 and over minus the share held by those under 40, in percentage points (Federal Reserve Distributional Financial Accounts, quarterly from 1989). *r* uses its annual mean.

Measuring absolute mobility

- **Definition** (Chetty et al. 2017, "The Fading American Dream"): share of children who earn more than their parents, comparing real household income at age ≈ 30.
- **Source**: Online Data Table 2, state $\times$ decadal birth cohort (1940s–1980s).
- **Assignment** (Prolific 2025): each respondent gets the value for the state they *grew up in* and their birth decade (2025 $-$ age).
  - It is the realized mobility of one's own cohort in one's home state (an outcome at ≈ 30), not mobility observed during childhood.
- **Scaling**: z-scored across respondents; $+$ = higher mobility.
- **Coverage**: series ends with the 1980s cohort $\Rightarrow$ respondents born 1990+ (age ≤ 35) drop out.

Birth decade	1940s	1950s	1960s	1970s	1980s
Age in 2025	76–79	66–75	56–65	46–55	36–45
N (estimation sample)	32	205	231	264	269

With home-state FE, variation is within state across decades $\Rightarrow$ highly collinear with cohort.

Absolute mobility and redistribution

Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on home-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variables:	Reduce income differences		More progressive taxes		Support redistributive proposal	
Spec.:	home FE	+coh.	home FE	+coh.	home FE	+coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Absolute mobility (SD)	-0.113***	-0.303*	-0.031	-0.119	-0.060**	-0.010
	(0.034)	(0.164)	(0.044)	(0.237)	(0.028)	(0.168)
Fixed-effects						
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)		Yes		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics						
Observations	998	998	998	998	998	998
R^2	0.04822	0.09092	0.04996	0.09185	0.04385	0.09866

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.113	–	–	–	−0.060	–
as % of the young–old gap	43%	–	–	–	45%	–

Absolute mobility and zero-sum beliefs

Prolific 2025: zero-sum beliefs on home-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variables:	Rich gain at others' expense		CEO pay at workers' expense		DEI: opportunity trade-off	
Spec.:	home FE	+coh.	home FE	+coh.	home FE	+coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Absolute mobility (SD)	-0.146***	-0.076	-0.081**	-0.121	0.006	-0.119
	(0.039)	(0.211)	(0.031)	(0.193)	(0.027)	(0.197)
Fixed-effects						
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)		Yes		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics						
Observations	995	995	988	988	992	992
R^2	0.06725	0.09496	0.05722	0.08043	0.05653	0.09399

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.146	–	−0.080	–	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	52%	–	108%	–	–	–

Absolute mobility and redistribution

ANES: support for redistribution on own-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution (VCF0809)	
Model:	state+yr (1)	+cohort FE (2)
Variables		
Own-state absolute mobility (SD)	-0.095***	-0.012
	(0.008)	(0.063)
Fixed-effects		
State	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)		Yes
Fit statistics		
Observations	30,252	30,252
R^2	0.02219	0.02650
Within R^2	0.00715	3.29×10^{-6}

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.095	–
as % of the young–old gap	45%	–

Inequality grown up with and redistribution

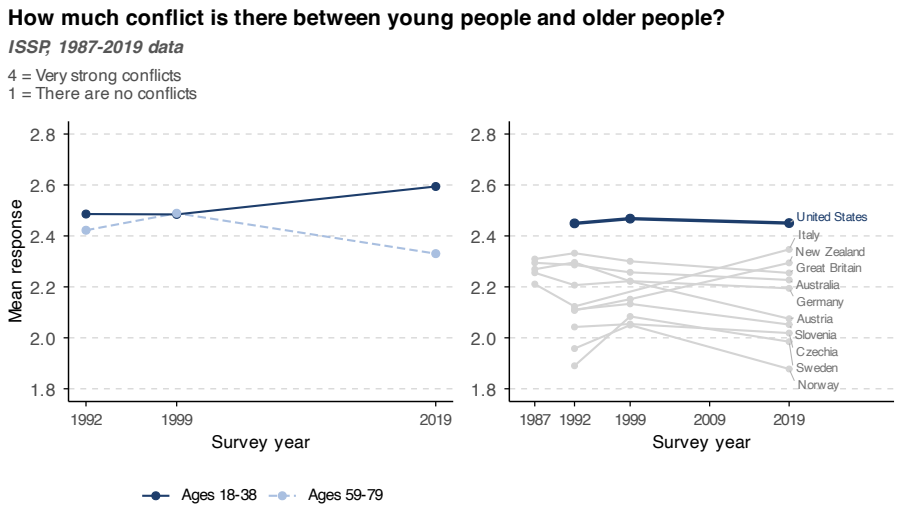
ANES: support for redistribution on the top-10% income share grown up with

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution			
Model:	base (1)	+coh. (2)	base (3)	+coh. (4)
Variables				
Top-10% share, formative average (SD)	0.075***	0.005		
	(0.011)	(0.021)		
Top-10% share, formative change (SD)			0.079***	0.013
			(0.008)	(0.013)
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	39,917	39,917	39,917	39,917
R^2	0.02235	0.03643	0.02252	0.03647

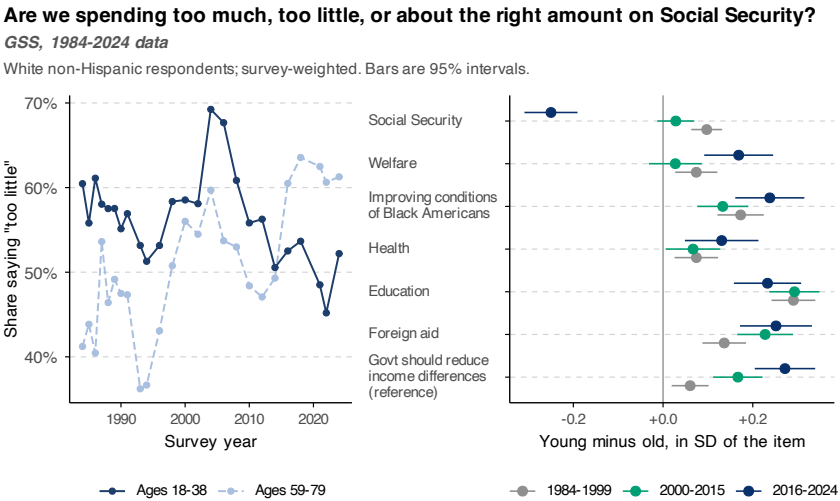
Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	+0.080	–	+0.080	–
as % of the young–old gap	16%	–	35%	–

Perceived conflict between young and old



Social Security: the one service where the young want less



Conclusions

- The US age gap is new.
  - It started emerging in the 80s and widened substantially around 2020–24.
- It is not the economic position of the young, but whether they believe the economic game is zero-sum or rigged.
  - Data from other surveys tends to agree.
- The US age gap is near the top of 91 countries, with the UK and the Nordics.
- Where the young are more zero-sum, they tend to be more pro-redistribution, across and within countries.

Future analysis

- Second survey wave
  - Questions on moral values, govt. trust, religiosity, and race-related beliefs.
  - In-depth measurement and differentiation of zero-sum and attribution beliefs.
  - An information provision or wording experiment generating exogenous belief variation.
- Geographic and micro variation
  - State and local-level age inequality measures: political representation (L2 voter files), policy tilt, real circumstances (housing, employment, etc.)
- Text analysis
  - Extracting zero-sum rich and zero-sum race narratives from Congressional speeches. Manifesto Project for cross-country.

Why is the US unique?

Possibilities:

- Old-age benefits and the political power of the old
- Two-party bundling of cultural and economic positions (majoritarian vs. proportional system)
- Political entrepreneurs (Sanders, Trump)

What explains sharp rise in gap post-2020?

- Prominent billionaires reshaping society (Musk, Bezos)
- Racial justice salience (BLM movement)
- Affordability crisis (inflation, housing) and youth unemployment
- Government debt worries (social security more salient)
- Historically old presidential candidates in 2020 and 2024

References I

American National Election Studies (2025). ANES time series cumulative data file, 1948–2024 [dataset and documentation]. University of Michigan and Stanford University.

Davern, Michael and Bautista, Rene and Freese, Jeremy and Herd, Pamela and Morgan, Stephen L. (2025). General social survey 1972–2024 [machine-readable data file]. NORC at the University of Chicago [producer and distributor]. Principal Investigator Michael Davern; Co-Principal Investigators Rene Bautista, Jeremy Freese, Pamela Herd, and Stephen L. Morgan. Sponsored by the National Science Foundation.

EVS/WVS (2022). European values study and world values survey: Joint EVS/WVS 2017–2022 dataset. GESIS Data Archive, Cologne, ZA7505. Data file version 4.0.0.